



Vishwas Mudagal, CEO,
Castle Rock Research



Sridharan Mani, director and CEO,
American Megatrends India



J A Bhavsar, CIO, ITM Group



Rahul De*, Hewlett-Packard chair
professor, quantitative methods and
information systems area, Indian
Institute of Management, Bangalore

such as NASSCOM and CII, which play a major role in defining the technology policy in India, must also come out in favour of FOSS, or at least take a firm position on FOSS,” says Rahul De, Hewlett-Packard Chair Professor, Quantitative Methods and Information Systems, IIM, Bangalore. Companies should take a firm stand in not only using FOSS, but also contributing back to the community. “It is about creating both the consumers and producers to create demand and supply in the FOSS ecosystem. India cannot have many consumers of FOSS unless there is an increase in the developers and facilitators contributing back to the community. Having said that, there has been a rapid increase in contributors on FOSS projects in India. For instance, recently a number of open source projects dedicated to the efficiency of Indian scripting have gathered momentum,” adds Shan Kadavil, country manager, Zynga (India).

Removing the obstacles

Steps are being taken, especially by technology veterans, to inspire the developer fraternity and make contribution a mass activity in India. “A good balance between cooperation and strong, competent leadership can ensure a large and strong FOSS community. However, it is difficult, and can take years—as is evident from many successful projects,” says Rohit Kumar Rai, sales director, India, SE Asia and Australia, EnterpriseDB.

IT companies are increasingly contributing back to the community. “As IT companies, we know about the different kinds of FOSS software, and understand the need to participate in leveraging it internally and externally. IT companies must sponsor user groups and communities developing FOSS software, and also have business models around FOSS, to make the ecosystem sustainable for the community,” says Bacche.

Companies like Red Hat, EnterpriseDB, MindTree, Intel, Zynga, etc, have seriously taken on the onus to build the community in India. For instance, within Red Hat India, there is a large team of 118N and L10N experts who work with the community to help in making FOSS projects available in more than a dozen Indian languages. This team

also works with the growing community of contributors to Fedora India. EnterpriseDB, too, is working on a strategy to enhance local contributions. “We hold training classes in India, and hire remote DBAs for customers. We are also looking at adding activities that provide incentives for people to get involved in the community, and make local contributions to the PostgreSQL project. Our objective is to ensure that the local community has both easy access to PostgreSQL, and the ability to contribute back to the community,” says Rai.

MindTree, on the other hand, is working on sharing knowledge to improve community participation. “We sponsor the JBoss user group. I head the Bangalore chapter of JBoss, where we hold monthly meetings. It is open to anyone who wants to talk about the Red Hat or JBoss stack. This close association with the community has helped us engage with popular authors of open source software, and organise ‘Tech Talks’ for the community whenever they travel to India. For instance, we recently invited the FOSS community in Bangalore for a session with Gavin King, the author of Hibernate,” says Bacche.

Zynga India has also been actively contributing back to the Membase open source project (co-founded by Zynga), while Intel India has played a crucial role in the MeeGo project and in building the community at the university and college level. “We work on increasing awareness about the importance of contributing to the community, by showing the developers how open source opens one to peer review, which helps enhance their skill-sets. Further, we collaborate with colleges, giving them access to our open source tools, webinars, etc, to generate ideas among students and sow the seeds of community building at the grass-roots level,” says Narendra Bhandari, director (Asia Pacific), Intel Software and Services Group. By fostering a culture for contributing, India could evolve into being a prolific FOSS creator, rather than a mere consumer.

A consumer base—crucial to generate demand

Another crucial component of the Indian FOSS ecosystem is the consumer. Merely having a growing contributor community is not good enough. For any growth, the demand and supply